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Organisational psychology

Why bother? Becoming helpless and depressed at work when voice is non-instrumental in an unfair organizational environment

À quoi bon ? Impuissance et déprime au travail quand la prise de parole est inefficace dans un environnement injuste

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ABSTRACT

Reluctance to voice concerns in organizations because of resignation is often depicted as an example of learned helplessness. This statement is made without clear evidence that these states are indeed similar. We address this gap in the literature by explicitly linking diminished voice behaviors and the phenomenon of learned helplessness. Building on the learned helplessness literature, we explored how perceived non-instrumentality of voice in unfair working environments contributes to the emergence of helplessness feelings. We hypothesized that helplessness feelings, in turn, contribute to resignation through reduced engagement in voice behaviors and an increase in depressive symptoms, in accordance with learned helplessness theory. Respondents were 305 workers who completed an online survey of justice perceptions, voice instrumentality, helplessness feelings at work, voice behaviors, and depressive symptoms. Results corroborated the proposed framework in that perceptions of low voice instrumentality in unfair working contexts were significant predictors of workers' helplessness feelings. Further, as hypothesized, helplessness feelings were

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linked to fewer voice behaviors and more depressive symptoms, especially when voice instrumentality was low in unfair contexts, emphasizing the role of past voice instrumentality at work.

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Résumé

La réticence à la prise de parole au sein des organisations en raison de la résignation est souvent présentée comme un exemple d'impuissance apprise. Ce constat est réalisé sans preuves claires que ces deux états sont effectivement similaires. Nous visons à explicitement vérifier cette correspondance en établissant un lien entre les comportements de diminution de la voix au travail et le phénomène de l'impuissance apprise. En nous appuyant sur la littérature relative à l'impuissance apprise, nous avons étudié comment la perception de faible instrumentalité de la voix dans des environnements de travail injustes contribue à l'émergence de sentiments d'impuissance. Conformément à la théorie de l'impuissance apprise, nos hypothèses impliquent qu'un haut niveau de sentiment d'impuissance contribue à une résignation en réduisant l'engagement dans les comportements d'expression et en augmentant les symptômes dépressifs. Nous avons interrogé 305 salariés concernant leurs perceptions de la justice, d'instrumentalité de la voix, de sentiments d'impuissance au travail, des comportements de voix et de leurs symptômes dépressifs. Les résultats ont corroboré nos hypothèses en ce sens que les perceptions d'une faible instrumentalité de la voix dans des contextes de travail injustes étaient des prédicteurs significatifs des sentiments d'impuissance des travailleurs. De plus, un haut sentiment d'impuissance au travail était lié à moins d'utilisation de la voix et à davantage de symptômes dépressifs, en particulier lorsque l'instrumentalité de la voix était faible dans des contextes injustes soulignant le rôle de l'instrumentalité de la voix passée au travail.

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People typically try to avoid situations they perceive as "negative" (e.g., unpleasant, stressful, unwanted, or harmful experiences) by taking action (Bukowski, Fritsche, Guinote, & Kofta, 2017; Greenaway et al., 2015) and thereby protect their well-being and comfort. Therefore, individuals are expected to endeavor to avoid such negative situations in significant areas of life, including the workplace. In organizational settings, where employees may lack the power to address the causes of unwanted situations directly, they often engage in "voice behaviors" to express their concerns. Such behaviors bring issues of concern to the attention of supervisors, with the hope of prompting them to implement necessary changes (Gorden, 1988; Hirschman, 1970; Morrison, 2023). However, in practice, individuals may hold back from engaging in voice behaviors in negative situations if they believe that speaking up will not be effective for bringing about desired change (Knoll, Wegge, Unterrainer, Silva, & Jønsson, 2016; Morrison, 2014, 2023; Pinder & Harlos, 2001). The decision to withhold voice—and thus to refrain from sharing information that could potentially lead to change (i.e., organizational silence; Morrison, 2023)—may arise from feelings of resignation, as individuals perceive that voicing their concerns is futile and that they lack control over the situation (Pinder & Harlos, 2001; Van Dyne, Ang, & Botero, 2003). This passivity is worrisome, especially when workers experience adverse consequences and do not take action to address important concerns.

Although considerable attention has been directed towards studying voice behaviors, the predominant focus of research has been on accumulating knowledge regarding antecedents and consequences

of such behaviors rather than on theory building and knowledge integration (Morrison, 2023). Consequently, the factors responsible for the decline in voice behaviors over time remain ambiguous in the existing literature (Knoll et al., 2021). When voice behaviors are absent or limited due to resignation, scholars have suggested for over 20 years that this phenomenon represents "learned helplessness" (e.g., Harlos & Knoll, 2021; Knoll et al., 2016; Knoll, Hall, & Weigelt, 2019; Knoll et al., 2021; Morrison & Milliken, 2000; O'Donovan, De Brún, & McAuliffe, 2021; Whiteside & Barclay, 2013), but this assertion lacks explicit confirmation and testing (Andrieu, Milhabet, Denis-Noël, & Steiner, 2024). Alternative explanations exist for reluctance to voice opinions or concerns, such as protecting oneself or others (Van Dyne et al., 2003). These alternative explanations do not align with a basis in resignation, because they propose that workers are reluctant to voice primarily due to fear of repercussions, such as punishment or reprobation. Therefore, clearly establishing that the reduced (or absence of) use of one's voice is a consequence of resignation, triggered by the same factors that cause learned helplessness (i.e., learned action-outcome non-contingencies in negative situations; Maier & Seligman, 1976, 2016; Maier & Watkins, 2005; Peterson, Maier, & Seligman, 1993), is essential for advancing our comprehension of why individuals restrain from using voice and for proposing relevant interventions to help restore its use. Further, a clearer understanding of the mechanism behind the diminished use of voice has the potential for proposing broader applications of research on learned helplessness and its consequences. For instance, learned helplessness research shows how psychologically healthy individuals may develop depressive symptoms (Abramson, Seligman, & Teasdale, 1978; Alloy & Abramson, 1982; Peterson et al., 1993; Seligman, 1975). If the same underlying factors lead individuals to withhold their voice, the emotional outcomes could parallel those observed in cases of learned helplessness.

Therefore, the primary objective of this study is to investigate explicitly whether learned helplessness serves as a plausible explanation for the limited use of voice due to resignation motives within the organizational context. Unlike the experimental research supporting this explanation for limited use of voice in a laboratory simulation (Andrieu et al., 2024), the study presented here focuses on the experiences and perceptions of workers within their organizational environments, thus providing an ecological perspective on resignation to voice as a form of learned helplessness.

1. Negative situations in organizations

At work, employees might feel they are being treated poorly by a supervisor, not receiving adequate pay for their efforts, experiencing discrimination, or prevented from receiving clear information regarding a decision. These perceptions are observed in extensive research in the field of organizational justice (e.g., Rupp, Shapiro, Folger, Skarlicki, & Shao, 2017). Such events are evaluated negatively by employees and are generally perceived to be "unfair." Perceptions of justice at work have contributed to understanding how fairness (or unfairness) affects attitudes and behaviors of workers (for reviews see, for example, Colquitt, Hill, & De Cremer, 2023; Colquitt & Zipay, 2015; Rupp et al., 2017; Silva & Caetano, 2016; Steiner, 2020). Perceptions of fairness in the workplace are central to understanding what individuals consider to be acceptable or unacceptable, and Brockner and Wiesenfeld (2019) argue that organizational justice encompasses a broad range of topics within organizational psychology that are not exclusively labeled as "organizational justice" (e.g., organizational civility, abusive supervision, organizational ethics, diversity, discrimination, etc.). Organizational justice can be examined considering four related but independent dimensions (Colquitt, 2001): distributive justice, which pertains to equitable resource allocation; procedural justice, which focuses on the fairness of decision-making processes, including consistency and lack of bias; interactional justice, which involves how respectfully and sensitively authorities communicate decisions and interact with employees; and informational justice, which relates to the clarity and relevance of explanations provided for decisions and policies. When any of these dimensions are violated, perceptions of fairness in the workplace are likely to suffer and a situation is likely to be perceived as "negative" by employees.

Workers are extremely attentive to the decisions made by authorities and the nature of their interactions with them and interpret the outcomes as salient cues regarding the fairness of the environment and how they are likely to be treated in the future (Cropanzano, Byrne, Bobocel, & Rupp, 2001; Lind, 2001; Van den Bos, 2001). Fairness theory suggests that workers analyze a situation by evaluating if the treatment could have been more favorable, seeking who is responsible, and considering whether

the authority should have acted differently. We can expect people to try to act on their environments to prevent such situations from occurring or to attenuate the consequences of an already present unfair situation. By doing so, they can avoid being at the mercy of an unfavorable environment and gain a sense of control.

2. Voice behaviors as control attempts

Workers can try to control aversive situations at work by expressing their opinions, concerns, or suggestions to an authority figure with decision-making power (e.g., supervisor, hierarchical superior). Such acts are referred to as using "voice" in the organizational literature (Chamberlin, Newton, & Lepine, 2017; Hirschman, 1970; Morrison, 2014, 2023). By communicating their opinions regarding a present or future situation, workers can try to defend their interests, and therefore contribute to making the situation more satisfactory for them. Workers can exert voice via different channels, from speaking directly to an authority in power, to using grievance procedures, or to depositing propositions in suggestions boxes (Harlos, 2001). Voiced content can be of different forms. It can take a "promotive" form to constructively address organizational malfunctions or enhance organizational functioning (e.g., proposing novel ideas or new ways to perform tasks), or it can be "prohibitive" in order to prevent negative consequences from occurring (e.g., generating awareness, addressing dissatisfaction; Maynes & Podsakoff, 2014).

These voice behaviors can be interpreted from a control perspective: expressing an opinion, a suggestion or a concern in an attempt to modify a situation (promotively or prohibitively) is an act of control (Lind, Kanfer, & Earley, 1990; Shapiro & Brett, 2005). Indeed, voice is considered as an extra-role, self-initiated behavior by the individual, aiming to alter the status quo. However, these voiced expressions may or may not be instrumental to influencing or changing the situation (Avery & Quiñones, 2002): the voiced content may be heard and acknowledged by authorities, independently of whether the content leads to changes or other impacts on workers' environments. Focusing on the "learning process" of the ineffectiveness of the action, required if learned helplessness is indeed involved in the process, we note that an employee first attempts to act on their work environment, to control it by using voice, and then observes whether their actions influence the situation or not (i.e., no control over the situation). When individuals perceive that their actions do not provide the desired outcome, they are in situations of action-outcome non-contingency. In these circumstances, their perceptions of control can decrease and negatively impact their future actions (i.e., using voice again; Kofta & Sędek, 1989; Leotti & Delgado, 2011; Rauvola & Rudolph, 2022; Skinner, 1995).

3. Learned helplessness and diminution of voice

The repetition of action-outcome non-contingencies contribute to one's learning history of interacting with the environment and ultimately decrease perceptions of control over it. Maier and Seligman (1976, 2016) initiated research on the absence of control by studying the behavioral modifications of animals in conditions of loss of control: animals became apathetic, showing signs of helplessness after repeated exposure to electric shocks they could not escape or influence. This phenomenon was called "Learned Helplessness" (Maier & Seligman, 1976, 2016; Peterson et al., 1993; Seligman, 1975). The same helplessness and resignation effects were found in humans exposed to uncontrollable aversive noises (Hiroto & Seligman, 1975; Koller & Kaplan, 1978) or to unsolvable puzzles (Kofta & Sędek, 1989; Pittman & Pittman, 1979); Soral, Kofta, & Bukowski, 2021). Learned helplessness theory indicates two conditions that must be met to create the conditions necessary for helplessness to develop: (1) situations must be perceived as negative and (2) one's actions must fail to address those situations, leading to learning that actions are inefficient (action-outcome non-contingency; Overmier, 2002; Peterson et al., 1993).

Voice instrumentality, which refers to the degree to which voiced opinions are perceived to have an impact on a decision (Avery & Quiñones, 2002), can also be interpreted in a control perspective. That is, having a low level of perceived voice instrumentality at work means that workers do not perceive the concrete impact of their voice (i.e., a situation of action-outcome non-contingency): They have experienced instances where their inputs are ineffective. Therefore, according to learned helplessness

theory, repetitively perceiving low instrumentality of one's voice in an unfair environment (i.e., past voice attempts were ineffective so unfair situations could occur again), could give rise to a sense of helplessness because of the perceived action-outcome non-contingency. We therefore propose our first hypothesis based on this reasoning.

H_1. Low voice instrumentality and perceptions of low fairness in the workplace will be associated with greater helplessness feelings, with their interaction accentuating helplessness feelings.

According to learned helplessness theory (Kofta, 1993; Maier & Seligman, 1976, 2016; Peterson et al., 1993), if individuals are unable to perceive the impact of their actions on a negative situation (in our case, they perceive low instrumentality of their voice in unfair contexts) and therefore develop helplessness feelings, they will engage in fewer attempts to control the situation in the future. Feelings of helplessness are an important factor in understanding why people may stop using their voice due to resignation in unfair environments for two reasons. First, and as previously stated, individuals must apprehend and learn the lack of action-outcome contingencies (Peterson et al., 1993), suggesting that helplessness feelings should arise from repeated failure to control the situation with voice. Second, the reduction or the absence of voice behavior can be motivated either by fear for oneself or colleagues (fear of repercussions for speaking up) or by resignation (disengagement; Van Dyne et al., 2003). As we are only interested in the latter, if learned helplessness is indeed operating, helplessness feelings among workers must be present to indicate that resignation is responsible for the diminished use of voice. That is, absence of voice as a result of resignation motives indicates that the individual is passive in the situation, as with learned helplessness (Maier & Seligman, 1976, 2016). Furthermore, to test if learned helplessness is operating in a given context, theorists indicate that all of its components (i.e., causes, mediator, and consequences) must be verified (Peterson et al., 1993). Specifically, workers should indeed have a low perception of voice instrumentality in an unfair environment (causes), leading to feelings of helplessness from learning that their actions are ineffective (mediator), which ultimately results in reduced voice behaviors aiming to alter the problematic situation (consequence). Thus, we hypothesize that feelings of helplessness mediate the relationship between voice instrumentality and voice behaviors (i.e., a preference to remain passive due to helplessness) when there are perceptions of low voice instrumentality in unfair working conditions.

H_2. The effect of voice instrumentality on voice behaviors will be mediated by helplessness feelings with the importance of the indirect effect moderated by the level of fairness perceptions in the working environment. In less fair situations, the indirect effect of voice instrumentality on voice behaviors through helplessness feelings will be weaker than in fair situations. Thus, low voice instrumentality will be associated with greater helplessness feelings, which in turn will be associated with low use of voice when the work situation is perceived to be unfair.

Feelings of helplessness are also related to an emotional state that highly resembles depressive symptoms (i.e., sadness, hopelessness, passivity, lethargy, lower self-esteem; Alloy & Abramson, 1982; Miller, Rosellini, & Seligman, 1977; Miller & Seligman, 1975; Peterson et al., 1993; Seligman, 1975). Indeed, feelings that control over a negative situation is impossible might increase stress levels and generate exhaustion over time (Peterson et al., 1993). Therefore, it is plausible that if a worker feels powerless to change negative situations in such an important context of life such as work, depressive symptoms could emerge (Peterson et al., 1993).

H_3. The effect of voice instrumentality on depressive symptoms will be mediated by helplessness feelings with the importance of the indirect effect depending on the level of fairness perceptions in the working environment. In less fair situations, the indirect effect of voice instrumentality on depressive symptoms will be weaker than in fair situations. Thus, low voice instrumentality will be associated with greater helplessness feelings which in turn will be associated with more depressive symptoms when the work situation is perceived to be unfair.

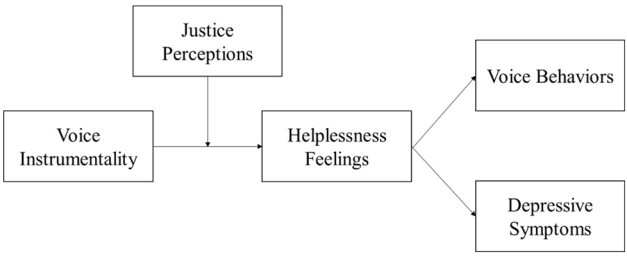

Fig. 1. Proposed theoretical model.

4. Study overview

To test our hypotheses, we conducted a cross-sectional survey targeting a diverse group of working professionals. This design enabled us to explore participants' perceptions of their actual work environments, enhancing the ecological validity of our findings and providing field-based data to complement the lab-based studies on this topic (Andrieu et al., 2024). The relationships among the variables explored in our hypotheses are illustrated in Fig. 1.

5. Method

5.1. Sample and data collection

Participants for an online study presented as a questionnaire on "work-life quality" were solicited via the crowdsourcing platform "Prolific Academic." The filters to be eligible to participate were: (1) being a native English speaker, (2) being employed, and (3) having a direct supervisor or manager. Participants were granted 1.50£ for their participation in the study estimated to take 15 to 20 minutes. Sample size was determined based on previous studies testing similar models (Jiang & Johnson, 2018; Liu, Luksyte, Zhou, Shi, & Wang, 2015). Initially, 320 individuals responded; however, the data from 15 respondents (4.6%) were discarded for one or more of the following reasons: the participant indicated being unemployed ($n = 2$), did not indicate being supervised by a manager ($n = 7$), did not correctly specify the right answer to more than one of the attention check items ($n = 2$), or did not complete the questionnaire ($n = 4$). The final sample for data analysis consisted of 305 participants (61% female) between 19 and 66 years old ($M = 38.6$, $SD = 10.9$), residing in Great Britain ($n = 270$, 88.5%), the United States ($n = 21$, 6.9%), Australia ($n = 5$, 1.6%), Canada ($n = 4$, 1.3%), Ireland ($n = 2$, 0.7%), or New Zealand ($n = 2$, 0.7%); one respondent did not specify the country of residency. Participants indicated being employed in various working sectors such as retail ($n = 65$, 21.3%), education ($n = 55$, 18%), or health ($n = 34$, 11.1%; details available in Appendix A) with an average tenure of 6.3 years.

5.2. Measures

5.2.1. Organizational justice

To assess general perceptions of workplace fairness, we used the 20-item organizational justice scale proposed by Colquitt (2001). This scale is an indirect measure of the four dimensions of justice at work: distributive, procedural, informational, and interpersonal. Respondents answered on a 5-point Likert scale (1 = "To a very small extent"; 5 = "To a very large extent"). Four items measured distributive justice ($\alpha = .88$, $\omega = .88$), seven items measured procedural justice[1] ($\alpha = .88$, $\omega = .88$), four

[1] As one item for measuring procedural justice perceptions may be related to the perception of voice instrumentality ("Do you have influence over the outcomes arrived at by those procedures?"), we conducted two confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) comparisons to determine if retaining the item as procedural justice affected model fit. The first compared two five-factor models, one with the 20 items of the justice scale corresponding to their defined dimension factor and the voice instrumentality

items assessed interpersonal justice ($\alpha = .95$, $\omega = .95$), and five items measured informational justice ($\alpha = .91$, $\omega = .91$). We computed composite scores to obtain a general justice perceptions score based on the average of the four-dimension subscales. Composite reliability (cf. Murphy & Davidshofer, 2005) of this composite scale was .96.

5.2.2. Voice instrumentality

We developed four items for this study, based on Brockner et al. (2001), to assess perceived past impact of the respondent's voice on their organizational environment (Appendix B). For example, one item was, "The opinions I express at work have an impact on my supervisor's decisions." Respondents answered using a scale ranging from 1 "Strongly disagree" to 7 "Strongly agree." Internal consistency reliability was high ($\alpha = .93$, $\omega = .94$).

5.2.3. Voice behavior

Five items based on Turnley and Feldman (1999) were written to assess the willingness to express personal opinions regarding negative work situations (Appendix B). Example items included, "I usually let my supervisor(s) know when something seems wrong at work." The response scale ranged from 1 "Strongly disagree" to 7 "Strongly agree," and internal consistency reliability was good ($\alpha = .86$, $\omega = .87$).

5.2.4. Helplessness feelings

As helplessness is characterized by the perception that outcomes are independent of one's actions and by cognitions indicating a preference for passivity rather than action (Peterson et al., 1993), we created a six-item scale to assess how much a person has integrated action-outcome non-contingencies at work and feels that it's useless to act (Appendix B). For example, two items were: "It is useless to try to change the way things are done where I work," and "Whatever I say, it won't change the manner I'm treated at work." The response scale ranged from 1 "strongly disagree" to 7 "strongly agree." Internal consistency reliability was high ($\alpha = .91$, $\omega = .92$).

5.2.5. Depressive symptoms

To measure depressive symptoms, we used the nine-item scale of the PHQ-9 (Kroenke et al., 2001Kroenke, Spitzer, & Williams, 2001), which assesses present and/or recent depressive symptoms. It was previously used in an organizational justice study (Lang, Bliese, Lang, & Adler, 2011). The scale is a self-report measure of the presence of depressive symptoms over the previous two weeks, with responses ranging from "never" (1) to "nearly every day" (4). Internal consistency of this measure was high ($\alpha = .90$, $\omega = .90$).

Additionally, the questionnaire contained four "attention check" items, for example, "To verify that you are paying attention, please select 'disagree' for this item." For the original scales developed for this study (voice behavior, instrumentality, and feelings of helplessness), the items were initially developed in English and validated by a native English-speaking co-author.

6. Results

All analyses were conducted using Jamovi Statistical Software (v. 2.2.5).

items attributed to a fifth factor, and the second with the potentially problematic item attributed to voice instrumentality rather than to procedural justice. Model fit was better when the item was retained as procedural justice ($\Delta AIC = -67$). The second comparison involved the five variables used to test the hypotheses of the study: general justice, voice instrumentality, helplessness feelings, voice behavior, and depressive symptoms. The models compared either included or excluded this item from the score for procedural justice in computing the composite measure of justice. Model fit was better in the case where the item was included ($\Delta AIC = -9$). We therefore retained the original scale containing this item as an indicator of procedural justice. Details of these analyses are available by contacting the first author.

Table 1
Means, standard deviations, and correlations of variables.

Variable	*M*	*SD*	AVE	CR	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1. Gender[a]	1.39	0.49	–	–	–							
2. Age	38.7	10.9	–	–	.03	–						
3. Tenure[b]	75.6	91.5	–	–	.01	.34***	–					
4. Justice	3.41	0.80	.621	.87	.12*	.01	.01	**.787**				
5. Voice behavior	4.85	1.20	.575	.87	.04	.12*	.02	.39***	**.755**			
6. Voice instrumentality	4.34	1.37	.788	.94	.14*	.05	.02	.73***	.62***	**.883**		
7. Helplessness feelings	3.31	1.37	.658	.92	−.12*	−.01	.00	−.63***	−.54***	−.70***	**.806**	
8. Depressive symptoms	1.68	0.62	.517	.90	−.04	−.06	−.02	−.30***	−.27***	−.24***	.37***	**.714**

AVE: average variance extracted; CR: composite reliability. Values in bold are the square roots of each factor's AVE.
[a] Female = 1, male = 2.
[b] Measured in months.
* $p < .05$.
*** $p < .001$.

6.1. Measurement quality

We conducted a Confirmatory Factor Analysis (CFA) to test the structure and relationships of the five measured constructs in our survey (available in Appendix C): general justice perceptions (the mean of the four justice dimension scores), voice instrumentality, voice behaviors, helplessness feelings, and depressive symptoms. The model fit was acceptable regarding the following criteria (Hu & Bentler, 1998): relative χ^2 is less than 3 (χ^2/df = 2.65), root mean square error of approximation is less than .08 (RMSEA = .074), and comparative fit index and Tucker-Lewis index are equal to or greater than .90 (CFI = .91; TLI = .90). To test for convergent validity, we calculated the average variance extracted (AVE) for the five measured factors in our CFA. As shown in Table 1 (which also presents the descriptive statistics for the study), the AVEs for each factor are above the threshold of .50, indicating satisfactory levels of convergent validity in the factors (Hair, Hollingsworth, Randolph, & Chong, 2017). Discriminant validity was tested by comparing the square root of each factor's AVE (shown in bold in Table 1) to all inter-factor correlations (Fornell & Larcker, 1981; Hair, Hollingsworth, Randolph, & Chong, 2017; Hair, Black, Babin, & Anderson, 2010). All the AVE values in Table 1 are greater than their corresponding row and columns correlations, indicating sufficient discriminant validity among the measured factors.

6.2. Common method bias

To address common method bias (CMB), we first used Harman's single-factor test (Harman, 1976). The test estimated that the shared variance among items was only 37%, below the 50% threshold, suggesting that common method bias did not significantly influence measurement. However, this indicator is criticized as not being a robust representation of CMB (Podsakoff, MacKenzie, Lee, & Podsakoff, 2003). Because we did not collect data on a social desirability scale or include a marker variable in the survey, we therefore used the common latent factor method (CLF; Podsakoff et al., 2003). The addition of the CLF in the model did not significantly change the AVE of the factors (differences in AVE should not be greater than .20; Appendix C), reinforcing the assumption that the survey was not significantly affected by CMB (Podsakoff et al., 2003).

6.3. Tests of hypotheses

For all analyses, the predictor variables were centered in all our models (Dalal & Zickar, 2012). Hypothesis 1 (H_1) proposed that low voice instrumentality and low perceptions of fairness in the workplace would be associated with greater helplessness feelings, with their interaction accentuating the feelings of helplessness. We conducted a hierarchical regression analysis with age, gender, and tenure as control variables because they potentially impact perceptions of fairness at work (Dulebohn

Table 2
Regression coefficients for the moderated regression analysis of voice instrumentality on helplessness feelings depending on justice perceptions.

Variable	*b*	*SE*	*t*	R^2	F
Step 1				.524	65.8
Age	.00	.00	.31		
Gender	−.03	.11	−.32		
Tenure	.00	.00	.23		
Instrumentality	−.52***	.06	−8.77		
Justice	−.42***	.10	−4.20		
Step 2				.531	56.1
Age	.00	.00	.50		
Gender	−.02	.11	−.19		
Tenure	.00	.00	.09		
Instrumentality	−.53***	.06	−9.01		
Justice	−.44***	.10	−4.40		
I*J	−.08*	.04	−2.03		

I: Instrumentality; J: Justice.
* $p < .05$.
*** $p < .001$.

Table 3
Conditional indirect effect at specific levels of the moderator (justice perceptions) when treating helplessness feelings as a mediator between voice instrumentality and voice behaviors.

Moderator: justice perceptions	Indirect effect	SE	LL 95% CI	UL 95% CI
+1 SD	.13**	.042	.050	.216
Mean	.11**	.038	.043	.193
−1 SD	.10**	.035	.034	.172

** $p < .01$.

et al., 2016; Goldman, 2001; Lee & Kawachi, 2019). The first step included the control variables, voice instrumentality, and justice perceptions as predictors of helplessness feelings and the second step included the interaction of the latter two predictors. This analytical strategy allowed us to assess the role of each predictor first, and then their combined effect with the interaction. As shown in Table 2, the analysis revealed that the first model was significant, $F(5, 299) = 65.8$, $p < .001$, $R^2 = .524$; both voice instrumentality and justice perceptions were significantly negatively associated with helplessness feelings (respectively $b = -.51$, $p < .001$ and $b = -.42$, $p < .001$) and the control variables did not significantly contribute to the regression. The second model, adding the interaction of voice instrumentality and perceptions of justice ($F(6, 298) = 56.1$, $p < .001$), explained additional variance beyond the first one as indicated by the significant coefficient for the interaction, $b = -.08$, $p < .05$ ($\Delta R^2 = .006$). A graphical representation of the moderation for high and low values of justice perceptions (−1 *SD*; +1 *SD*) is presented in Fig. 2. Simple slope analyses were significant for low and high levels of perceived justice ($b = -.46$, $p < .001$ and $b = -.60$, $p < .001$, respectively). As shown in Fig. 2, helplessness feelings were greater in the presence of low voice instrumentality and in unfair contexts, in correspondence with H_1. As for the interaction, these effects are accentuated with voice instrumentality being particularly beneficial in reducing helplessness for individuals in highly fair situations.

Hypotheses 2 and 3 (H_2 and H_3) posited that helplessness feelings would mediate the effects of voice instrumentality on voice behaviors and depressive symptoms, depending on the level of perceived justice in the workplace (moderator). To test these hypotheses, we conducted two moderated mediations, one for each outcome (i.e., voice behavior and depressive symptoms) with bootstrapped 95% confidence intervals ($n = 5000$). Regarding voice behaviors, conditional indirect effects were found to be significant for low and high justice perceptions. As shown in Table 3, the indirect effect of voice instrumentality via helplessness on voice behaviors was weakest when justice was low (−1 SD), $b = .10$, $p < .01$, 95% CI [.036; .171] and strongest when justice was high (+1 SD), $b = .13$, $p < .01$, 95% CI [.051; .215]. The direct effect of voice instrumentality on voice behaviors was significant in this model, $b = .52$,

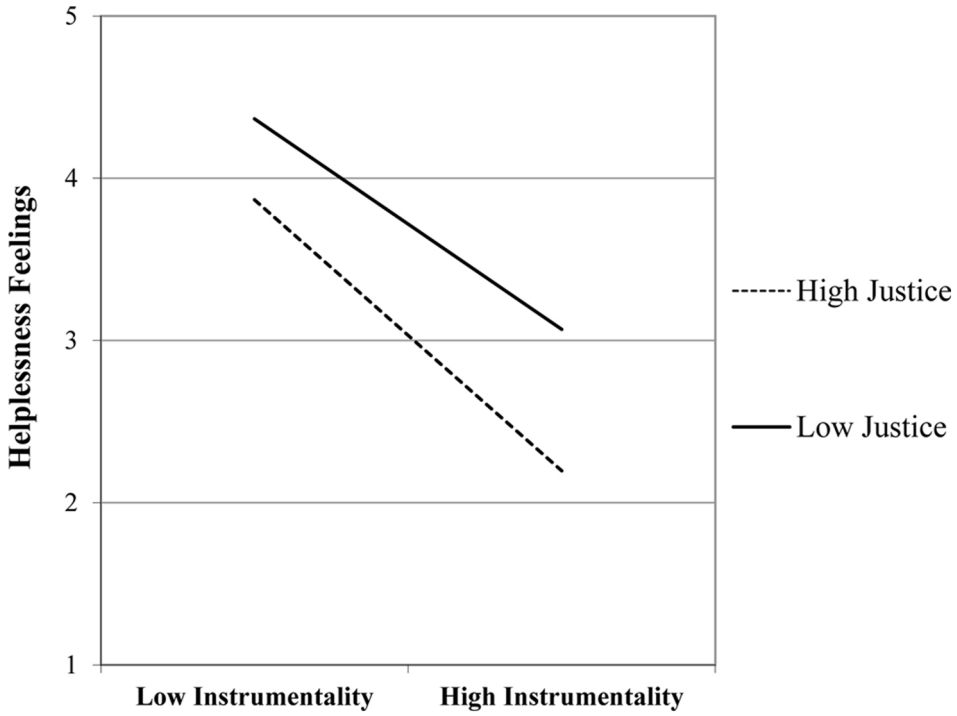

Fig. 2. Relationship between voice instrumentality and helplessness feelings as moderated by fairness.

Table 4
Conditional indirect effect at specific levels of the moderator (justice perceptions) when treating helplessness feelings as a mediator between voice instrumentality and depressive symptoms.

Moderator: justice perceptions	Indirect effect	SE	LL 95% CI	UL 95% CI
+1 SD	−.09***	.029	−.153	−.040
Mean	−.08***	.023	−.132	−.041
−1 SD	−.07**	.023	−.122	−.029

** $p < .01$.
*** $p < .001$.

$p < .001$, 95% CI [.390; .657]. Thus, with lower voice instrumentality, employees were less inclined to use voice behaviors. Furthermore, voice behaviors of employees in unfair environments were lower than those in fair environments because of the weaker indirect effect of voice instrumentality through helplessness, indicating support for Hypothesis 2 (H_2).

With regards to depressive symptoms, conditional indirect effects were significant for low and high justice perceptions as well. As shown in Table 4, conditional indirect effects analysis revealed that the effect of voice instrumentality on depressive symptoms via helplessness feelings was weaker when justice was low (−1 SD; $b = -.07$, $p < .01$, 95% CI [−.117; −031]) and stronger when high (+1 SD; $b = -.09$, $p < .001$, 95% CI [−.155; −040]). In this model, the direct effect of voice instrumentality on depressive symptoms was not significant, $b = .06$, $p =$ ns. Thus, with lower voice instrumentality, employees were more likely to develop depressive symptoms. Furthermore, employees in unfair environments indicated more depressive symptoms than those in fair environments because of the weaker indirect effect of voice instrumentality through helplessness, indicating support for Hypothesis 3 (H_3).

7. Discussion

Our study integrates the literature on learned helplessness by applying it to organizational settings and identifies factors with the potential for explaining how helplessness and silence develop in unfavorable working environments. Specifically, our study addresses the lack of empirical investigation regarding the reduction of voice behaviors due to resignation, which is often attributed to learned helplessness in the literature (Andrieu et al., 2024). Using field data from 305 workers, we explored whether the underlying factors leading to learned helplessness and its expected consequences are indeed similar.

The organizational justice literature has highlighted the important role of employee voice in organizations and its effects on numerous other outcomes (Lind et al., 1990; Shapiro & Brett, 2005; Thibaut & Walker, 1975). However, further investigation is required to understand the factors that motivate employees either to utilize or to refrain from using voice, particularly when doing so can genuinely influence situations to become fairer and more favorable for their well-being (Harlos & Knoll, 2021; Knoll et al., 2021; Morrison, 2023). The connection between employees' reluctance to use their voice due to resignation and the commonly employed concept of learned helplessness to explain this state has not been clearly established in the literature (Andrieu et al., 2024). Our study aimed to address this gap by exploring whether the factors described in learned helplessness theory align with those that lead employees to experience a sense of helplessness when it comes to expressing their opinions at work. We considered workers' perceptions of their working environments in terms of fairness and the perception of their past attempts to use voice to affect negative work situations to predict their willingness to use voice in unfair work contexts. Our data indicates that the lack of impact of voice (i.e., low voice instrumentality) in unfair work contexts resulted in greater helplessness feelings among workers. Thus, to better understand why individuals feel helpless at work, it seems relevant to consider the perception of their past attempts to control their working environment using voice and the result of those attempts, as described by learned helplessness theory (i.e., voice instrumentality). Interestingly, by examining the results for people who perceive fair work environments, we can see that helplessness feelings are particularly reduced when voice is perceived as instrumental. This result underscores the importance of taking into consideration the expressed opinions of workers.

Our study also explored the motivational and emotional consequences expected in a state of learned helplessness. Lower perceptions of voice instrumentality related to higher feelings of helplessness, were linked to fewer voice behaviors and more depressive symptoms, particularly when perceptions of justice in the workplace were low (i.e., unfair situations are likely to happen). Thus, the perceived impact of past voiced opinions is noteworthy for the emergence of helplessness feelings and their related motivational and emotional consequences for workers. These consequences are well documented in the helplessness literature where learned helplessness is linked to fewer attempts to control the negative situation (i.e., resignation) and greater depression-like symptoms (e.g., apathy, passivity, lower self-esteem; Abramson et al., 1978; Maier & Seligman, 2016; Miller et al., 1977; Miller & Seligman, 1975; Peterson et al., 1993; Ric, 1996; Seligman, 1975).

7.1. Theoretical implications

Our study indicates the importance of considering individuals' perceptions of the past impact of their voice on aversive situations (i.e., contingencies between voice behaviors and results), identified as crucial determinants of their perceptions of control (Leotti, Iyengar, & Ochsner, 2010; Leotti & Delgado, 2011; Skinner, 1995), and therefore, of learned helplessness (Bukowski et al., 2017; Kofta & Sędek, 1989; Soral et al., 2021). The findings of our study are consistent with the learned helplessness literature as experiencing negative situations is not the only factor determining helplessness emergence: Individuals must have tried to control the situation and learned that their action did not have an impact (i.e., lack of action-outcome contingency; Kofta & Sędek, 1989; Peterson et al., 1993). Similarly, research on organizational voice and silence and, more precisely, silence motivated by resignation (acquiescent silence; Pinder & Harlos, 2001; Knoll & van Dick, 2013) should consider past voice attempts and their perceived impact (instrumentality) toward the situation or in the organizational environment instead of considering one situation alone.

Having the opportunity to voice an opinion at work is an important determinant of favorable outcomes for workers (Avery, McKay, Wilson, Volpone, & Killham, 2011; Avery & Quiñones, 2002; Brockner et al., 1998; Lind et al., 1990; Shapiro & Brett, 2005), but our model suggests limits to such effects: if employees become accustomed to working in unfair environments where past voice attempts had no impact, future voice opportunities may not be used as employees develop helplessness feelings and become less likely to voice in new, potentially unfair situations (even when control is indeed possible). Over the long run, if someone's voice is never impactful, negative consequences are likely, especially in unfair work contexts. This is important to consider for the organizational justice literature as helpless workers may refrain from speaking up in new unfair situations and therefore continue to endure those situations in the future (i.e., increasing the impact of unfair working settings).

The present study also contributes to research on the determinants of voice in organizations. Sherf et al. (2021) indicated that voice behavior is related to approach motives and is greatly related to one's perceived impact in the situation. Thus, our results provide empirical evidence for the importance of the perceived impact of voice by linking lower levels of voice behaviors to helplessness feelings and by proposing lack of past voice impact as an important determinant of it.

Finally, our study provides an alternative explanation for the emergence of depressive symptoms related to justice issues at work by considering the impact of past attempts to control justice issues and increasing feelings of helplessness. Lower levels of justice have been linked to high levels of depressive symptoms, but the causality is still discussed (Lang et al., 2011). The model proposed and its results in our study indicate that some depressive symptoms may be explained by the lack of voice's instrumentality in an unfair environment, leading to helplessness feelings and the emergence of depressive symptoms.

7.2. Practical implications

Even though voice has been related to many benefits for workers and organizations, it is crucial to consider whether voice is perceived by employees to be instrumental in producing perceivable changes in the organization. Thus, managers or authorities who rely on policies providing high voice opportunities, but with little consideration for the voiced message and acting in accordance with it, should be aware of how low voice instrumentality can impact workers' control perceptions and well-being at work. Recognizing the impact of employees' attempts to voice propositions in an organization is not just about providing a platform for their expression; it is about active listening by managers. Such an approach fosters a healthier, more inclusive, and ultimately more successful organizational environment. In instances where implementing changes is not feasible for valid reasons, employees can accept such decisions if management is transparent in providing explanations for refusals (principles of procedural justice; e.g., Richter, König, Koppermann, & Schilling, 2016). Furthermore, delivering this information respectfully, adhering to interactional norms like warmth and empathy, also fosters individuals' understanding (Patient & Skarlicki, 2010). Implementing training sessions or programs to educate both managers and employees on effective communication strategies and the importance of active listening can enhance the quality of interactions and in turn increase the likelihood that voiced concerns will be taken seriously and addressed appropriately. To ensure a robust follow-up, it could be useful for managers or authorities to document voiced concerns diligently alongside the actions taken. Regularly revisiting the status of these concerns and keeping workers informed showcases a sense of accountability and a steadfast commitment to proactively addressing issues raised by employees.

In cases of severe problems such as bullying or other forms of mistreatment at work, helplessness feelings and silence may develop if voiced concerns or calls for help do not have impact on the situation (Harlos, 2001). For helpless victims, the consequences could be serious as they may remain helpless and continue to suffer passively in similar future situations. An additional concern is that this ongoing inability to alter an unfavorable working environment can lead to the objectification and dehumanization of workers by supervisors, as well as to self-objectification by the workers themselves. Studies in social perception indicate that individuals lacking in agentic qualities—such as assertiveness, confidence, and resilience—are often seen as *less human* (Formanowicz et al., 2018). This is particularly concerning, as workers unable to assert themselves or express distress in challenging environments may be perceived as less human by their supervisors, potentially exacerbating psychological strain

on them (Caesens, Stinglhamber, Demoulin, & De Wilde, 2017). Self-objectification may also occur, as workers view themselves through the lens of dehumanization, further undermining their psychological well-being (Auzoult, 2021; Hamel, Villieux, Montalan, & Scrima, 2024). Organizations must therefore try to foster an environment where employees feel psychologically safe and encouraged to voice their concerns without fear of reprisal. This involves not only creating policies that support open communication but also actively encouraging potential victims or witnesses to voice.

7.3. Limitations and further research

The limits of our study can orient future research. Broadly, the research method used here (i.e., cross-sectional) is not suitable for drawing direct conclusions about causality among our observed variables (Maxwell & Cole, 2007). Helplessness feelings were self-reported here and could be examined through observed behaviors in the future. Our participants reported behavioral intentions regarding voice behavior, but their actual behavior in unfair situations should be studied. Further research is also needed to observe if the non-instrumentality of voice across multiple attempts to influence unfair situations could lead to fewer reactions against future unfair situations. Adapting learned helplessness laboratory-controlled protocols to field settings could reinforce conclusions that unfairness and low voice instrumentality lead to resignation (e.g., Bukowski, Asanowicz, Marzecová, & Lupiáñez, 2015; Soral et al., 2021). In addition, future research should investigate other possible negative consequences of helplessness. For example, helpless workers could be more susceptible to emotional exhaustion or depersonalization (Lee & Ashforth, 1990; Schermuly & Meyer, 2016) as they have learned that their working environment is not controllable and feel helpless about changing it (Bianchi & Schonfeld, 2016). Finally, helplessness feelings could also disrupt work performance as long-term control deprivation has been shown to affect executive attention and information selection on a cognitive level (Bukowski & Kofta, 2017; Ric & Scharnitzky, 2003; Soral et al., 2021). Generally, because of the negative effects of learned helplessness, future studies should explore it as a possible long-term consequence of unfair working environments and determine whether its consequences are confined to the workplace or generalize to other life domains.

Ethics statement

The study was approved by the ethical committee of the authors' university, Université Côte d'Azur (Ethics Committee for Non-Interventional Research; No. 2021-36).

Consent to participate

Informed consent was obtained from all individual participants included in the study.

Disclosure of interest

The authors declare that they have no competing interest.

Data availability

The data that support the findings of this study are available on OSF at https://osf.io/waphr/?view_only=dc8a91f51d444ff8adacad8242a63bfa.

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Appendix A. Supplementary data

Supplementary data (Appendices A–C) associated with this article can be found, in the online version, at https://doi.org/10.1016/j.prps.2024.11.003.

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